

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Pentecost 9
Another Kind of Freedom ~ Radical Love
2 August 2026

Preaching: ML

Worship Leading: LVF & Janette Tovar

David's & Laurel's Last Sunday

Strips of paper in programs for prayers

Organ Prelude-Concert

Ave Maria op. 106 no. 2 – Sigfrid Karg-Elert

Fantasia super *Jesu meine Freude* BWV 713 – J. S. Bach

Sonata no. 1 in F minor – Felix Mendelssohn

1. Allegro moderato e serio
2. Adagio
3. Andante recitativo
4. Allegro assai veloce

Dr. Abraham Ross, *Guest Organist*

Chiming of the Hour

[Laura and Janette center chancel]

Welcome

LVF

Words of Gathering

JT & LVF

If we boil down the purpose of all of our living.

If we follow the thread of all our questions.

If we uncover what is beneath all this grief and discovery:

We find love, love, love,

The very heartbeat of God.

Love, sturdy and steadfast.

Love, heartbreaking and heart-opening.

Love, as in, we belong to each other.

Love, as in, we will let sorrow turn us towards compassion.

Love, as in, we will let compassion guide us
towards wise action.

Love, as in, God is within each living thing.

Love as in, God moves between us.
*Love, as in, God is the possibility
that stretches before us.*

This morning, we give thanks for love
in all its dimensions, as we open our hearts,
our minds, and our bodies
in this time set apart.

[adpt/enfleshed]

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering.

***Hymn of Gathering**  **Love Now Ascending - NICAEA.pdf**

[Laura center chancel]

***Prayer of Awareness**

LVF

[All turn towards choir]

***Introit** “Love is love is love” Abbie Betinis
Cathedral choir

[Janette to lectern]

***The Lord’s Prayer**

JT

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Laura to center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace**

LVF

Though the mystery of God remains beyond grasp,
the Spirit gifts us with glimpses of justice,
with touches of love,
and with whispers of truth.

Always and everywhere,
the Wisdom of God is being revealed,
that we might live and love differently together
free from the ways that destroy.

Together, we recognize the Holy Mystery that surrounds us
and reveals the ways of collective liberation - and beauty.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are now invited to share this greeting with those near you.

Please be seated

[Janette to lectern]

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from the Gospel of Luke* JT
Speaking to a great number of disciples and a large crowd of people from all over the region,
Jesus shared these words of wisdom, written in the Gospel of Luke, chapter 6...

“To you who hear me, I say: love your enemies. Do good to those who hate you,
bless those who curse you, and pray for those who mistreat you.
When they slap you on one cheek, turn and give them the other; when they take your coat, let
them have your shirt as well. Give to all who beg from you. When someone takes what is yours,
don’t demand it back.

“Do to others what you would have them do to you. If you love those who love you, what credit
does that do you? Even those who choose to harm others, love those who love them. If you do
good only to those who do good to you, what credit does that do you? Even those who choose to
harm others do as much.

“If you lend to those you expect to repay you, what credit does that do you? Even those who
choose to harm others lend to others expecting to be repaid in full. Love your enemies and do
good to them. Lend without expecting repayment, and your reward will be great. You’ll rightly
be called children of the most high, since God is good even to the ungrateful and the wicked.

“Be compassionate, as your loving God is compassionate. Don’t judge, and you won’t be
judged. Don’t condemn, and you won’t be condemned. Pardon, and you’ll be pardoned.
Give, and it will be given to you: a full measure—packed down, shaken together and running
over—will be poured into your lap. For the amount you measure out is the amount you’ll be
given back.”

This is the Gospel of Radical Love.
Thanks be to God!

[Abe short transition Laura center chancel]

Prayers with the People

LVF

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

As we come to this time of silence and prayer, we are invited once again to remember that we are not alone. Whether we come from near or far, we are wrapped in a love that has the power to turn enemies into friends and friends into family.

As we breathe in the peace that surrounds us in this space we make holy by our presence together, we pray that the Divine will remind us we are all the people who carry the image of God within us, around us, and among us.

Writing prayers

Let us now be in silence, together.

Silence

[Abe transition out of silence as people come forward to offer prayers and light candles]

[Laura center chancel when all are seated]

Prayer of Our Hearts

[Abe transition for choir]

Meditation Music

“You Are Music” from *Symphony For Voices 3: Mycelial*. David Harris
Laude

“You are music...you are the universe greeting itself for a brief moment.” ~Dr. Roger Penrose

“Introit and Kyrie” from *Requiem in D Minor* W.A. Mozart
Cathedral Choir

“Let perpetual light shine on us. We sing to the God of love, the love that marks our beginning and our ending. God have mercy, Christ have mercy.”

“Beati Quorum Via” Charles Villiers Stanford
Laude

“Blessed are they who walk with God, whose way is steadfast love.”

[Abe transition Michael to pulpit, choir to seats]

Sermon

Radical Love

ML

[Abe transition Janette to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity

JT

‘Love,’ writes Carter Heyward, ‘is a conversion to humanity - a willingness to participate with others in the healing of a broken world and broken lives.

Love is the choice to experience life as a member of the human family, a partner in the dance of life, rather than as an alien in the world or as a deity above the world, aloof and apart from human flesh.’

Giving of our time, our talents, and our money is one way we can enter the dance of life, in this our time and place. We invite you to give from your resources for the work we are doing together

FOOD AT FIRST QR Code

Offertory Anthem

“Ah, Non Credea, Ah! Non Giunge”

Vincenzo Bellini

Laurel Irene and Dr. Abraham Ross

*“I didn’t believe that love could fade so quickly. Perhaps my tears can revive you. Ah!
Human thought can’t manage to grasp the happiness I feel. I can barely believe my own senses.
Love is revived! Let us always unite in a single hope. From this place that we live, we shall build
a heaven of love.”*

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator’s praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Megan to lectern toward end of doxology]

***Offering Prayer**

JT

God of Grace and Love, remind us as we leave this time together,
that you made us in your image
and filled us with your Spirit of Love.

As we offer all our gifts and talents, O God,

give us the vision to use your wildly inclusive love,
so that by our words and our actions,
we may dismantle the walls of division
and co-create our lives with your grace and love,
on this day and on all the days to come.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

[Laura & Michael center chancel]

Life at First Church
-Recognition of David and Laurel

ML & LVF

Words of Blessing

ML

The world now is too dangerous
and too beautiful for anything but love.

May your eyes be so blessed you see God in everyone.
Your ears, so you hear the cry of the poor.

May your hands be so blessed
that everything you touch is a sacrament.
Your lips, so you are speaking nothing but the truth in love.

May your feet be so blessed you run
to those who need you.

And may your heart be so opened,
so set on fire, that your love,
your love, changes everything.

[A Black Rock Prayerbook]

May it forever be so.
May it forever be so for all of us!

Choral Response

“I Remember, I Believe” Bernice Johnson Reagon
Cathedral Choir

***Hymn for the Journey**
God Whose Love is Always Stronger

HYFRYDOL

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[Laura center chancel]

Postlude

Fugue in G major K. 574 – W. A. Mozart

Dr. Abraham Ross, *Guest Organist*

Inside The Music

Reflecting on almost a decade here at FCCLA, I feel overwhelmed by the magnitude of love and connection I've shared in community with you all. The music today are several pieces that I really wanted to sing. They connect around a broader, universal integration of love and being. Some are more obvious, like Abbie Betinis' "Love Is Love Is Love" that she wrote for simple group singing, though the message is anything but simple in our day and age. The famous "Ah, Non Credea, Ah! Non Giunge" from Bellini's "La Sonnambula" is a monster anthem to love. The opera's finale, it brings everyone together around a believe that love is the central architect of life, and we can hope to love in perpetuity. I wrote "Symphony For Voices 3: Mycelial" as a long-form improvisation. We'll do the last part of it today, which was inspired by the physicist Roger Penrose. I heard him speak passionately about our connection to the universe, ergo, all things. I amended his quote a little for the music. In the actual quote I sourced he says: "You are music. . . You are the universe experiencing itself for a brief moment before dissolving back into the eternal field structure." Every time I think about this I'm moved. The world around us, everything we know and understand, are expressions of the same eternal field structure. For whatever reason we come into being and then we return to that oneness. That, to me, is the essence of love, and it makes me want to love deeply in order to remain close to the source for the time that I am aware of my place in the universe. I feel like Mozart was experiencing a similar reflection as he wrote his final piece, the "Requiem in D Minor." The opening is so tender, and even the double fugue in the "Kyrie" rings with depths of passion and promise. Although he chose the text of the death mass for which he was commissioned, the music explodes with the beauties of life and love. It rattles through us reminding us to awaken into the energy of this moment. He's calling to us still to live and love and be in concert with each other. The simple, elegant beauty of Stanford's "Beati quorum via" speaks for itself as an expression of commitment to love as a way of life. And I had to program something by Bernice Johnson Reagon today. She is one of the composers whose capacity to communicate deep truths has so consistently marked my time here with you all. I love hearing and singing her music. In this last verse of "I Remember, I Believe" she resonates these other voices by saying "My God called to me in the morning due, the power of the universe knows my name. Gave me a song to sing and sent me on my way, I raise my voice for justice, and I believe." The whole song has a careful balance around knowing and unknowing. In the song, she releases that which she can't fathom

into places that won't weigh her down as she picks up the song that she's been given and sings it for all to hear. That's a promise to live by.